

Injection-Led Turnarounds:
Audience Capital, Operating Systems,
and the Limits of the Celebrity Turnaround Thesis

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Abstract

This paper tests whether celebrity “injection-led turnarounds” constitute a scalable institutional investment thesis. Nineteen candidate cases were screened against pre-specified inclusion rules; three were admitted, of which one passes all four rules strictly. The sole computable treatment return is Wrexham AFC: a 54.40x paper MOIC over 3.67 years (approximately 197.1% per year under the single-cash-flow assumption), computed from a reported USD 2.5 million entry to a transacted but unrealized USD 136 million October 2024 minority mark. An exact log decomposition attributes 71.0% of the value move to revenue growth and 29.0% to revenue-multiple expansion; the EBITDA margin term is not separable because the club is loss-making. The figure is an upper bound on reported-figures paper return because it treats entry enterprise value as total paid-in capital and ignores more than GBP 25 million of owner-funded cumulative losses. Two further treatment cases, Aviation Gin and Mint Mobile, exited to strategic buyers at filed maxima of up to USD 612 million and USD 1.35 billion respectively, with 44.9% and 31.1% of those maxima contingent on earnouts; entry values were never disclosed for either, so no investor-level return is computable for any brand case. A non-celebrity PE control set yields three equity-computable turnarounds (median 3.19x), one adverse 3G case (Kraft Heinz, 0.265x price over ten years), and five total-loss cases (0.0x). The pre-specified sign test was not run: it requires at least two computable MOICs and the sample contains one, unrealized. StepStone stratum percentile placement and the sector counterfactual decomposition were not computable from the dataset; both are stated as gaps rather than filled by assumption. Survivorship sensitivity gives pooled medians of 54.4x, 54.4x, and 27.2x under 0%, 25%, and 50% imputed total-loss rates. On this evidence the narrower variant of the thesis is provisionally supported: one documented case exists in which an audience injection coincided with outsized paper value creation, mostly revenue growth, plus two large filed asset-level exits with no computable investor return. The full scalable institutional thesis is not supported. Rejection is not warranted either; the data are insufficient to reject, and the Wrexham case stands as an existence proof.

Keywords: celebrity investment, turnarounds, private equity, value creation decomposition, survivorship bias.

Dataset: v1.0 (2026-09-26), cases, controls, and benchmarks tables; evidence files a1 through a4; analysis scripts and figures archived with the paper.

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1 Theory

1.1 Definition

An *injection-led turnaround* is an acquisition of control or a significant stake (at least 20% equity or de facto control) in an existing, underperforming or underexploited operating asset, after which the investor injects a resource that could not have been purchased at the entry price, and the asset's value subsequently rises in a way traceable, at least in part, to that injection. Four conditions must all hold: (I1) the investor acquires at least 20% equity or de facto control; (I2) documented underperformance or undervaluation at entry; (I3) a post-acquisition injection, dated and described rather than merely asserted; (I4) a verifiable entry valuation traceable to a primary source. The definition deliberately excludes celebrity-as-founder deals (no acquired asset exists, so no turnaround return can be computed), pure endorsements (no equity), and capital-only injections (standard control buyouts, which belong in the control set).

The object of interest is the return attributable to the injection above what a capital-only buyer would have earned. That requires the benchmark to be a buyout-like control, not the public market alone, because the treatment includes control, leverage, and illiquidity, all of which carry their own expected compensation.

1.2 Injection types

Three distinct injection mechanisms appear in the candidate set, and they carry different causal claims.

Audience injection. The investor converts a pre-existing personal audience into asset-level demand: sponsorship inventory, distribution, earned media, and direct-to-consumer attention. The documented case is Wrexham AFC, where sponsorship revenue rose from GBP 1.05 million in FY2022 to GBP 17.3 million in FY2025, and 57.7% of FY2025 turnover originated outside the UK, primarily North America. The documentary series "Welcome to Wrexham" is part of this mechanism, though its direct economics are disputed: the club's own accounts statement says the show delivers no direct financial return, while entertainment press claims GBP 350,000 to GBP 430,000 per episode, and the club separately paid a GBP 2.59 million marketing contribution toward the show in FY2025. Neither figure enters the return calculation.

Marketing-engine injection. The investor supplies a proprietary marketing and content operation, rather than a passive audience. The documented cases are Aviation Gin and Mint Mobile, both under Ryan Reynolds, where his Maximum Effort creative operation produced the advertising that accompanied each brand's growth. The mechanism is dated and described in the evidence file; what is not documented is the entry consideration or the exact stake, which bounds what can be computed.

Operating-system injection. The investor installs a managerial playbook: zero-based budgeting, ownership culture, meritocratic hiring, and unit-level cost control. The documented case is 3G Capital at AB InBev, where company-reported EBITDA margins expanded from 30.9% in 4Q 2008 to 39.3% for full year 2011. This injection is deliberately non-celebrity and serves as the favorable arm of the control set; the same playbook's adverse arm is Kraft Heinz.

The thesis under test is specific to the first two mechanisms: that audience or marketing capital, injected by a celebrity principal, produces turnaround returns that are distinct from and exceed capital-only control returns. The operating-system arm is a control, not a treatment case.

1.3 The scalability question

A case series of successful celebrity injections does not establish an investible thesis. Three conditions separate a repeatable institutional strategy from a set of anecdotes. First, the return must be measured at the investor level, net of all paid-in capital, and benchmarked against what control capital alone would have earned. Second, the mechanism must survive the selection problem: celebrities choose assets with latent potential, so the sample confounds picking with making. Third, the strategy must be scalable in equilibrium: whether the twentieth injection buyer obtains the same entry pricing and the same audience response as the first is a claim about a market that does not yet exist, and no case series can test it. This paper is structured to show, for each condition, what the data can and cannot establish.

1.4 The key-person problem

All three treatment cases trace to a single celebrity principal, Ryan Reynolds. Wrexham (with Rob McElhenney), Aviation Gin, and Mint Mobile all depend on his audience, his marketing operation, or both. A sample in which $n = 3$ cases share one person proves a person-specific playbook, not an institutional one. This is the key-person problem: even where the evidence favors the narrower claim, it cannot distinguish “celebrity injection works” from “this celebrity’s injection worked on these assets.” The failure-mode references sharpen the point: Salford City shows celebrity ownership plus spending stalling for six seasons in the fourth tier, and Crawley Town shows a hype-led injection ending in a distressed pass-on. Nothing in the admitted sample identifies the ex ante attributes that separate a Reynolds from a WAGMI United.

2 Data

2.1 Candidate set and inclusion rules

The candidate list was fixed before any return was computed. Nineteen candidates were identified from deal databases, press archives, and filings: eight sports-club cases and eleven consumer-brand cases. The inclusion rules (I1)–(I4) and exclusions (E1)–(E4) are stated in full in the methodology appendix; the screening log below applies them case by case.

Three cases were admitted. One, Wrexham AFC, passes all four rules strictly. Two, Aviation Gin and Mint Mobile, were admitted under a documented relaxation of (I4): their entry consideration and exact stake percentages were never disclosed, so no investor-level MOIC or IRR can be computed for either. They are retained because their exit legs are the best-filed figures in the set (a Diageo Form 20-F and T-Mobile 10-Ks), and because their (I3) injection mechanisms are the best-documented in the set. The consequence is enforced mechanically throughout: their entry-side cells are empty, no MOIC is reported for them, and they are excluded from the sign test and the survivorship pool.

2.2 Screening flow

Table 1 reproduces the PRISMA-style inclusion and exclusion log from the dataset methodology (v1.0). Sixteen candidates were excluded; several excluded cases are retained in the paper as failure-mode references or contrast cases, never as return evidence.

Table 1: Inclusion and exclusion log: 19 candidates screened, 3 admitted

#	Candidate	Verdict and criterion
1	Wrexham AFC (Reynolds/McElhenney)	INCLUDE. Passes I1 (100%, Feb 2021), I2 (National League, GBP 1.478m turnover baseline), I3 (audience injection, dated 2022–2025), I4 (USD 2.5m entry via contemporaneous deal reporting).
2	Aviation Gin / Davos Brands (Reynolds)	INCLUDE (relaxed I4). Exit leg fully filed (Diageo 20-F, up to USD 612m); entry price undisclosed.
3	Mint Mobile / Ka’ena (Reynolds)	INCLUDE (relaxed I4). Exit leg fully filed (T-Mobile 10-Ks, up to USD 1.35B); entry price undisclosed.
4	Inter Miami CF (Beckham)	EXCLUDE. Fails I2: greenfield expansion franchise, not a turnaround.
5	Birmingham City (Knighthead; Brady 3.3%)	EXCLUDE. Fails I1 for the celebrity leg and I4 (Brady price undisclosed); control consideration irreconcilable (GBP 5.3m filing vs GBP 35m press).
6	Burnley FC (ALK; Watt minority)	EXCLUDE. Fails I3: the injection was leverage, not audience or brand (E3-like).
7	Salford City (Class of ’92 / Beckham)	EXCLUDE. Fails I4 (E4): entry valuations undisclosed. Retained as failure-mode reference.
8	Crawley Town (WAGMI United)	EXCLUDE. Fails I4 (E4): purchase price undisclosed. Retained as failure-mode reference.
9	LeBron James / Liverpool (FSG)	EXCLUDE. Fails I3: passive stake, no operational injection. Contrast case: 15–19x paper return with zero injection.
10	Passive athlete minority stakes	EXCLUDE. Fail I3/I4: minority, undisclosed, too early, too passive.
11	Casamigos (Clooney)	EXCLUDE. E1: founder. Benchmark for celebrity-brand exits only.
12	Kylie Cosmetics (Jenner)	EXCLUDE. E1: founder. Cautionary annex material; valuation disputed.
13	The Honest Company (Alba)	EXCLUDE. E1: founder. IPO then ~90% value destruction.
14	Teremana Tequila (Johnson)	EXCLUDE. E1: founder. No exit; ongoing.
15	Glacéau/Vitaminwater (50 Cent)	EXCLUDE. Fails I1 (~2.5% sweat-equity stake); E2-adjacent.
16	Adidas-Yeezy (West)	EXCLUDE. E2: licensor/partner, no equity. Failure-mode reference (partner-conduct termination).
17	Diageo/Combs (Ciroc, DeLeon)	EXCLUDE. E2/I4: no equity in Ciroc; dissolved Jan 2024, terms undisclosed.
18	Beachbody SPAC (O’Neal)	EXCLUDE. Fails I1/I3: advisor, no operating turnaround attempted.
19	The Parent Company SPAC (Jay-Z)	EXCLUDE. Same as 18; companion data point (~86% fall).

2.3 Labeling regime

Every figure in the dataset carries one of three labels, and the labels are enforced in every table in this paper. FILED denotes a figure taken from a regulatory filing or regulatory announcement (SEC 10-K/20-F, LSE regulatory announcement, SEC-filed company release). Press reports of filed accounts are REPORTED, not FILED, because the filing was not inspected directly. REPORTED denotes any press-reported figure, not audited. INTERIM_MARK denotes an unrealized valuation, never transacted; every use carries a mark date and a mark source. An empty cell means unknown, not zero, with one documented exception: the five total-loss controls carry 0 exits where the notes document a reported equity wipeout. Entry and exit values must be on the same basis (both enterprise value or both equity value); rows where the sources mix the two are flagged MIXED and excluded from ratio calculations.

2.4 Dataset version

The analysis uses dataset v1.0 (compiled 2026-09-26): `data/cases.csv`, `data/controls.csv`, `data/benchmarks.csv`, governed by `data/METHODOLOGY.md`. All monetary cells are in USD millions; GBP values were converted at 1.39 USD per GBP for February 2021 and 1.31 for October 2024, approximate monthly-average spot rates. Every computed value in Section 4 is reproduced by the archived analysis script, and the full computed-value table is archived alongside the dataset. The claim log accompanying this paper (`paper/claim_log.csv`) traces every quantitative claim to its input cell or named source.

2.5 Treatment cases in brief

Wrexham AFC. Acquired February 2021 by R.R. McReynolds Company LLC (Ryan Reynolds and Rob McElhenney) for a reported USD 2.5 million (REPORTED). Three consecutive promotions followed (National League champions 2022–23, League Two runners-up 2023–24, League One runners-up 2024–25), with the club competing in the Championship in 2025–26. Turnover rose from GBP 1.478 million (pre-takeover baseline, FY2020) to GBP 33.35 million in FY2025, roughly a 22-fold increase in five years, while the club remained loss-making every year of the ownership (FY2025 pre-tax loss GBP 14.85 million). In October 2024 the Allyn family acquired close to 15% at a reported valuation of about USD 136 million (INTERIM_MARK; mark date and source stated in every use). A June 2025 exploration of a stake sale at USD 475 million was not transacted and is not used. The Companies House filings were not inspected directly; all accounts figures are press reports of those filings.

Aviation Gin. Reynolds bought a “significant” stake in February 2018 as owner and creative director of a pre-existing brand. Diageo completed the acquisition of Aviation Gin LLC and Davos Brands LLC on 30 September 2020. The filed consideration (FILED, Diageo Form 20-F for the year ended 30 June 2021) is USD 337 million in cash plus contingent consideration of up to USD 275 million over ten years, for a filed maximum of USD 612 million. Up to 44.9% of the filed maximum is contingent, and earnout achievement is undisclosed, so the realized deal value is unknown. The consideration covers Davos Brands LLC as well (Astral Tequila, Sombra Mezcal, TYKU Sake), not Aviation Gin alone. Reynolds retained an ongoing ownership interest, so the exit was partial.

Mint Mobile. Reynolds acquired an ownership stake in late 2019, becoming owner and creative face of the existing MVNO. T-Mobile announced the acquisition of 100% of Ka’ena Corporation on 9 March 2023; the deal closed 1 May 2024. The filed maximum purchase price is USD 1.35 billion (FILED, T-Mobile 10-K for FY2023), paid 39% cash and 61% stock. At close, T-Mobile transferred USD 420 million cash and shares valued at USD 536 million, with a USD 17 million working-capital return, for net upfront fair value of USD 939 million (FILED, T-Mobile 10-K for FY2024); up to USD 420 million remains payable as an earnout on 1 August 2026, achievement unknown. The earnout is 31.1% of the filed maximum. Reynolds stayed on in a creative role; the exit was partial.

3 Methods

3.1 Return metrics

For case i , let C_0 be total paid-in equity capital at entry, C_t interim distributions, and V_T the exit value (realized) or latest reported valuation (unrealized, labeled INTERIM_MARK). Then

$$\text{MOIC}_i = \frac{\sum_t C_t + V_T}{C_0}. \quad (1)$$

Where only entry and exit values and the holding period T are known and interim distributions are zero or unknown, the annualized return is

$$r_i = \text{MOIC}_i^{1/T} - 1, \quad (2)$$

which equals the IRR only under the single-inflow/single-outflow assumption. That assumption is stated every time r_i is reported. For unrealized cases, $\text{TVPI}_i = (\text{Distributed}_i + \text{NAV}_i) / \text{PaidIn}_i$, with NAV_i the interim mark. Realized and unrealized cases are reported in separate tables; the pooled figure is labeled mark-inclusive. Per the methodology, no volatility-based risk measure is computed on any series containing marks, and the realized-only table is the primary result.

3.2 Benchmark design

Three benchmarks were specified before analysis. The primary peer is the StepStone deal-level buyout distribution (Brown and Yi, 2,937 fully exited global buyouts, 1984–2018): each treatment case is assigned to a stratum defined by sector, entry-year band, and deal-size bucket, and its MOIC is compared against that stratum’s median and quartiles. The operating and multiple components are benchmarked against Damodaran’s NYU Stern sector datasets (free, annual; EV/EBITDA, EV/sales, operating margins, ROIC), and Davis et al. (Management Science, November 2025; thousands of US buyouts, 1980–2013, matched on industry, size, age, multiunit status, and buyout year) supplies the causal prior for the operating improvement a generic control buyout achieves. The Kaplan–Schoar public-market equivalent is a secondary check only where a defensible sector index exists; for football clubs no traded sector index exists, so no PME is computed for Wrexham and no unrelated index is used as proxy.

Two of the three benchmark legs could not be executed on this dataset, and the paper states this as a gap rather than filling it by assumption. The StepStone stratum percentile placement is not computable: the dataset’s StepStone rows contain deal counts and value-creation shares but no stratum-level MOIC median or quartile distribution. The Damodaran sector counterfactual is not computable: the Damodaran rows in the dataset cover food processing, household products, retail grocery and food, hotel/gaming, healthcare services, and media, and there is no sports or football row; applying the media or hotel/gaming row as a proxy would be inventing a sector match, which was not done. The club’s loss-making status additionally blocks the margin terms of the counterfactual.

3.3 The log decomposition

For each case with entry and exit financials, enterprise-value growth is decomposed as

$$\frac{\text{EV}_{\text{exit}}}{\text{EV}_{\text{entry}}} = \frac{\text{Rev}_{\text{exit}}}{\text{Rev}_{\text{entry}}} \times \frac{m_{\text{exit}}}{m_{\text{entry}}} \times \frac{k_{\text{exit}}}{k_{\text{entry}}}, \quad (3)$$

with m the EBITDA margin and k the EV/EBITDA multiple. In logs,

$$\ln \frac{\text{EV}_{\text{exit}}}{\text{EV}_{\text{entry}}} = \ln \frac{\text{Rev}_{\text{exit}}}{\text{Rev}_{\text{entry}}} + \ln \frac{m_{\text{exit}}}{m_{\text{entry}}} + \ln \frac{k_{\text{exit}}}{k_{\text{entry}}}. \quad (4)$$

With leverage, the bridge from EV growth to equity MOIC runs separately through debt pay-down and distributions. The excess decomposition into (a) market beta, (b) replicable operating alpha, and (c) owner-specific residual was pre-specified but is not reported: its sector inputs are not in the dataset (Section 3.2).

3.4 Survivorship sensitivity

Media-visible samples overrepresent successes by construction, and no comprehensive registry of failed celebrity brands was found. The paper therefore reports a sensitivity bound, not a bias correction. For an imputed unobserved-failure rate $f \in \{0\%, 25\%, 50\%\}$, the pooled set is the observed computable MOICs plus $\text{round}(f \times n_{\text{observed}})$ imputed total losses (MOIC = 0), and the pooled median is reported at each f . The $f = 0\%$ column is the observed sample; the $f > 0$ columns are bounds. This is presented as a table, not a headline estimate, and no Heckman-style selection correction is attempted at this sample size.

3.5 Small-n inference rules

The following are licensed: medians, quartiles, and ranges; exact distribution-free confidence intervals for the median via order statistics; the sign test and Wilcoxon signed-rank test on excess returns versus the benchmark (exact two-sided p -values under the $\text{Binomial}(n, 0.5)$ null of zero median excess); permutation tests; sensitivity tables; one pre-specified primary test with everything else labeled exploratory. The following are not licensed: t -statistics or normal-based confidence intervals on $n = 10$ – 20 skewed returns; regressions with more covariates than roughly $n/10$ observations; “statistical significance” as proof; the mean as the headline estimate (means are outlier-dominated at small n); and any claim that the sample estimates a population parameter for “all injection deals.” The sample is a case series, not a random draw. When in doubt the paper shows the distribution, not a single number, and MOICs are reported to at most two decimals.

4 Results

4.1 Wrexham AFC: the only computable treatment return

Inputs (cases.csv row WRX-01): entry EV USD 2.5 million (REPORTED, February 2021); interim mark USD 136 million (INTERIM_MARK, October 2024 Allyn transaction, close to 15%); holding period 3.67 years; revenue at entry USD 2.05 million (GBP 1.478 million at 1.39); revenue at mark USD 34.98 million (GBP 26.7 million at 1.31). The EBITDA margin cells are empty; the club has been loss-making every year of the ownership.

The arithmetic is verified: $136/2.5 = 54.40x$. Annualized, $54.4^{1/3.67} - 1 = 197.1\%$ per year, under the single-cash-flow assumption (one inflow at entry, one outflow at the mark, no interim distributions). This is a paper return on reported figures, and it is an upper bound: the MOIC definition divides by *total* paid-in equity C_0 , but $54.40x$ treats C_0 as the entry enterprise value and ignores all follow-on funding. The notes cell documents cumulative pre-tax losses exceeding

GBP 25 million over four seasons, owner-funded through loans later repaid from club cash flows. True investor equity MOIC is lower than 54.40x by an unknown amount.

Decomposition. The EBITDA-margin term $\ln(m_{\text{exit}}/m_{\text{entry}})$ is not computable because the margin cells are empty. The implementable identity uses revenue multiples:

$$\ln \frac{\text{EV}_{\text{exit}}}{\text{EV}_{\text{entry}}} = \ln \frac{\text{Rev}_{\text{exit}}}{\text{Rev}_{\text{entry}}} + \ln \frac{(\text{EV}/\text{Rev})_{\text{exit}}}{(\text{EV}/\text{Rev})_{\text{entry}}}. \quad (5)$$

The decomposition is an identity, exact on unrounded values: $\ln(54.40) = 3.9964$; revenue growth $34.98/2.05 = 17.06x$, $\ln = 2.8369$ (71.0% of the log value); revenue-multiple expansion $3.888/1.220 = 3.188x$, $\ln = 1.1594$ (29.0%). At the displayed four decimals the check reads $2.8369 + 1.1594 = 3.9963$ against $\ln(54.40) = 3.9964$, a rounding difference in the last digit. Figure 1 shows the waterfall. Two readings follow. First, most of the move is revenue growth, which is the component most directly tied to the documented audience injection (sponsorship rebuild, global commercial income). Second, the 29% “multiple” term is a revenue-multiple term that conflates margin change with multiple change; the margin split the methodology specifies is blocked by the data, not by the analyst. Entry EV/Revenue was 1.22x and the mark implies 3.89x.

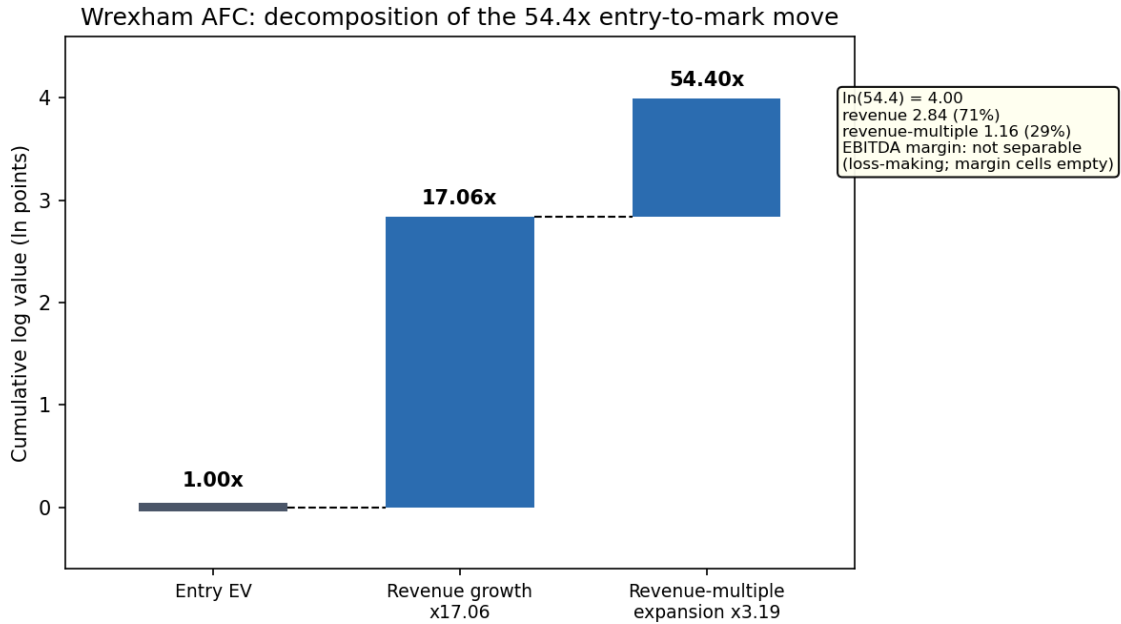


Figure 1: Wrexham AFC: log decomposition of the 54.40x entry-to-mark move. Revenue growth contributes 2.84 of 4.00 log points (71%); revenue-multiple expansion contributes 1.16 (29%). The EBITDA margin term is not separable because the club is loss-making at both ends.

4.2 Brand cases: exit-side evidence only

Aviation Gin. Filed exit maximum USD 612 million (USD 337 million cash plus contingent consideration of up to USD 275 million over ten years; FILED, Diageo Form 20-F). Up to 44.9% of the filed maximum is contingent and earnout achievement is undisclosed, so the realized deal value is unknown and USD 612 million is a maximum, not a price. The exit was realized in the sense that Diageo closed the acquisition on 30 September 2020; it was partial in that Reynolds retained an ongoing ownership interest. No entry value was ever disclosed and no exit revenue multiple is computable: revenue was never disclosed (only a scale proxy of about 53,000 US

cases in 2019 appears in the notes), and no spirits or beverage sector row exists in the dataset’s Damodaran set.

Mint Mobile. Filed exit maximum USD 1.35 billion (FILED, T-Mobile 10-K for FY2023). Net upfront fair value at close was USD 939 million (USD 420 million cash plus USD 536 million stock, less a USD 17 million working-capital adjustment; FILED, T-Mobile 10-K for FY2024). Up to USD 420 million, 31.1% of the filed maximum, remains payable as an earnout on 1 August 2026, achievement unknown. T-Mobile disclosed 50% annual subscriber growth and 70%+ annual revenue growth over the prior four years, but no subscriber count or revenue figure, so no exit multiple is computable and no wireless-telecom sector row exists in the dataset.

What the brand leg shows: two large, regulatory-filed asset-level exit values, both maxima with material contingent components, both realized as partial exits, both with documented injection mechanisms. What it does not show: any investor-level return (no entry value exists for either); whether the exits beat any benchmark; or that the injection caused the exit values. For Mint the (I2) leg is weak: the brand was already growing before entry, so the brand leg of the thesis is about injection-accelerated growth, not distress turnaround, and the paper does not describe Mint as distressed.

4.3 Controls

Seven non-celebrity PE turnarounds (CTL-01 to CTL-07; vintages 2002–2007, exits 2009–2018; a hand-picked mega-deal set, not a screened sample). Three rows are equity-computable, each from the notes cell with reconstructions flagged: Dollar General 2.50x (paper at IPO, about 150% paper gain on roughly USD 2.8 billion sponsor equity, 2.3 years); Hilton 3.19x (reconstructed equity, about USD 14 billion reported profit on USD 6.4 billion paid in, 11 years; REPORTED); HCA 3.28x (partial: Bain fund investors turned USD 956 million into USD 3.14 billion of proceeds, excluding the 2010 dividend recapitalization, 7 years). Median of the three: 3.19x. Range: 2.50x to 3.28x. Two further rows support EV-trajectory analysis only, not equity MOIC: Burger King 2.67x EV (2002 to 2010) and Alltel 1.02x EV (2007 to 2009). Hertz and Nielsen are indeterminate for ratios: the Hertz exit cell is the 2013 sale only, and the Nielsen ratio (0.72x) mixes entry EV with exit market capitalization and is excluded per the methodology.

3G playbook cases (n = 2). AB InBev is the favorable arm: no exit occurred; the stock roughly tripled between 2009 and 2015 (about 3.0x price, REPORTED, price basis only), alongside company-reported EBITDA margin expansion from 30.9% to 39.3% by 2011. Kraft Heinz is the adverse arm: ten-year price return negative 73.5% to USD 23.63 as of 26 September 2026 (price only, dividends excluded), an effective price multiple of 0.265x, versus Mondelez positive 39.6% and General Mills negative 47.4% over the same window. Kraft Heinz revenue was effectively flat (USD 26.3 billion in 2018, USD 25.8 billion in 2024; filed figures via secondary compilation), and the February 2019 write-down (USD 15.4 billion goodwill impairment, dividend cut, SEC subpoena) marks the failure. A defined brewing peer-relative return for AB InBev was not located in the reviewed public sources; that is a data gap.

Five PE total-loss and liquidation controls (CTL-10 to CTL-14: Energy Future Holdings, Toys “R” Us, Caesars, iHeartMedia, Neiman Marcus). Equity recovery 0.0x in all five rows, median 0.0x. Caesars and Neiman Marcus are near-total rather than clean total losses (residual reorganized equity existed; Mytheresa was excluded from the Neiman bankruptcy), so the table is evidence of loss severity, not a uniform zero-recovery series.

Benchmark context. The dataset’s industry aggregates are fund-level and cannot be converted into a deal-level MOIC distribution. They are reported here as context only: McKinsey median net IRR 16.4% for PE funds launched 2011–2020 (top quartile above 24%); pooled

one-year net IRR for buyouts of 4.9% in 2023; average buyout return about 6% for 2015–2025; buyout outperformance versus the S&P 500 of 20–27% over fund life (Harris, Jenkinson, and Kaplan, 2014); buyout fund-of-funds median PME 1.11–1.14. On value-creation shares: multiple expansion and cheap debt accounted for 59% of 2010–2022 buyout returns (McKinsey); in the StepStone dataset, multiple expansion contributed 19% of total value creation historically, attributed primarily to the market rather than GP actions, while GP-attributable multiple expansion was negative in the 2025 update (PE multiples increased less than those of like-vintage public equities). Figure 2 plots every group with its n labeled; no statistical claim about control distributions is licensed, because the control set is hand-picked, not screened.

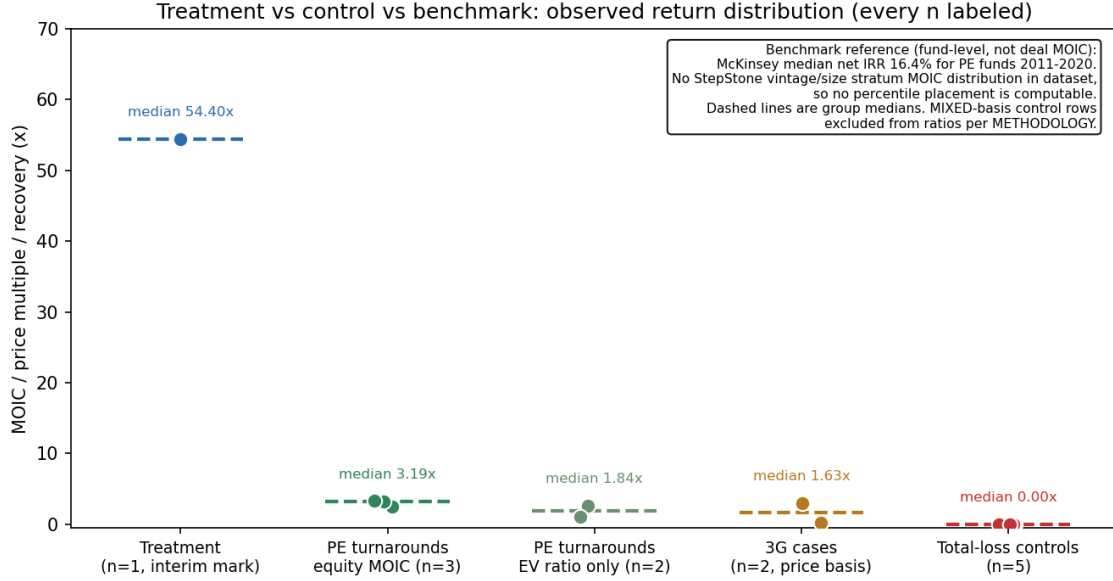


Figure 2: Treatment versus control versus benchmark: observed return distribution. Treatment $n = 1$ (Wrexham, interim mark, median 54.40x). PE turnarounds: equity MOIC $n = 3$ (median 3.19x) and EV ratio only $n = 2$ (median 1.84x), bases kept separate. 3G cases $n = 2$ (price basis, median 1.63x). Total-loss controls $n = 5$ (median 0.00x). Mixed-basis rows excluded from ratios per the methodology. Benchmark reference is fund-level, not a deal MOIC distribution; no StepStone stratum distribution exists in the dataset, so no percentile placement is computable.

4.4 Survivorship sensitivity

The treatment computable-MOIC set is $\{54.4\}$, with $n_{\text{observed}} = 1$. Aviation Gin and Mint Mobile have no computable MOIC and are excluded from the pool. Table 2 and Figure 3 report the pooled medians. At $f = 25\%$, $\text{round}(0.25 \times 1) = 0$ imputed failures, so the 25% column is identical to the observed sample; the bound only bites at $f = 50\%$ because $n = 1$. This is a sensitivity bound, not a bias correction, and it is presented as a table, not a headline.

4.5 Statistical honesty: what is not licensed

The pre-specified primary test (one-sample sign test and Wilcoxon signed-rank on median excess MOIC versus the stratum median) was not run. It requires at least two computable MOICs; the sample contains one, and that one is an unrealized interim mark, so there is no excess-MOIC series to test. No percentile placement versus StepStone was computed, because the stratum MOIC distribution is not in the dataset. No sector counterfactual decomposition was computed, because the sector inputs are not in the dataset. No PME was computed for Wrexham, because

Table 2: Survivorship sensitivity: pooled treatment median MOIC under imputed total-loss failures (MOIC = 0). Aviation Gin and Mint Mobile are excluded; they have no computable MOIC.

f (imputed total-loss rate)	Imputed failures	Pooled set	Pooled median
0%	0	{54.4}	54.4x
25%	0	{54.4}	54.4x
50%	1	{0.0, 54.4}	27.2x

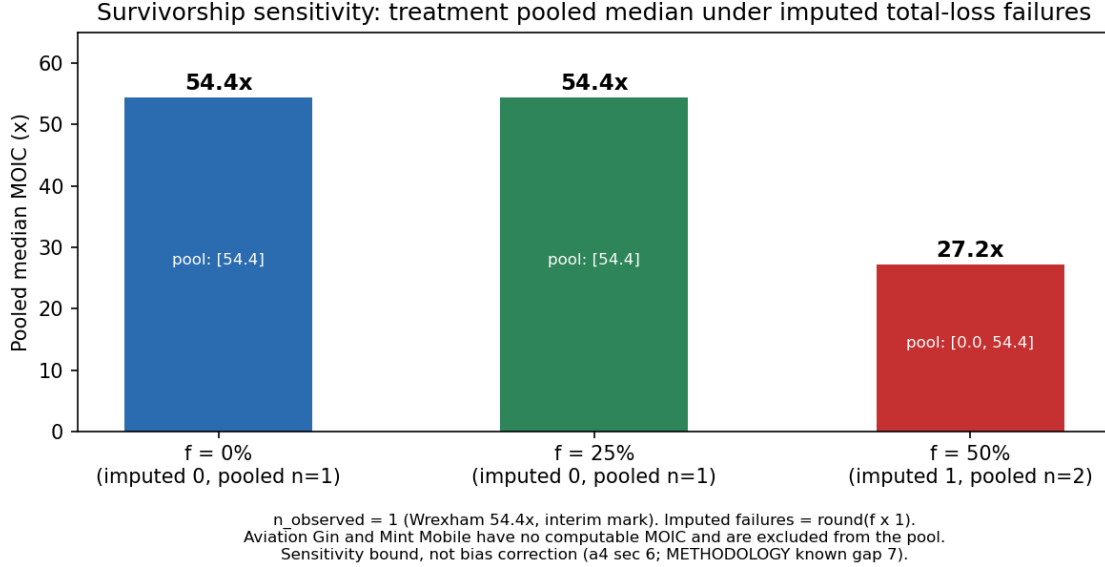


Figure 3: Survivorship sensitivity. $n_{\text{observed}} = 1$ (Wrexham 54.4x, interim mark). Imputed failures = $\text{round}(f \times 1)$. Sensitivity bound, not bias correction; the true unobserved failure rate is unknown.

no traded football-club sector index exists. No volatility-based risk measure was computed on any series containing marks. No regression was run; the cross-sectional specification is stated for future extension only. No annualized-rate comparison against benchmarks was made beyond the single-cash-flow 197.1% figure, reported with its assumption and its upper-bound caveat every time. No claim is made that the sample estimates a population parameter for “all injection deals.”

What is licensed and is reported: the verified 54.40x arithmetic; the exact log decomposition on revenue multiples; medians and ranges of the computable control values; the exit-side filed values with their contingent shares; the survivorship sensitivity table; and the explicit list of gaps above.

5 Discussion

5.1 What the evidence can say

Three statements survive the honesty filter. First, one documented case exists in which a celebrity-audience injection coincided with outsized paper value creation: Wrexham’s 54.40x

entry-to-mark move, of which 71% in log terms is revenue growth, the component most directly tied to the documented injection (the sponsorship rebuild from GBP 1.05 million to GBP 17.3 million, the North American commercial expansion). Second, two further injection cases reached large filed asset-level exits: up to USD 612 million (Aviation Gin) and up to USD 1.35 billion (Mint Mobile), with the earnout shares and the partial-exit structure stated exactly. Third, the control record shows that capital-only turnarounds produce both strong multiples (Hilton 3.19x, HCA 3.28x, Dollar General 2.50x) and total losses (five at 0.0x), and that an operating-system injection of documented quality can fail badly (Kraft Heinz 0.265x over ten years): injection, of any kind, is neither necessary nor sufficient for a good outcome.

5.2 What the evidence cannot say

The evidence cannot say whether Wrexham's return is excess to a benchmark, because no stratum comparison and no sector counterfactual are computable. It cannot say what any investor actually earned on any treatment case: Wrexham's figure is an unrealized mark that ignores follow-on funding, and the brand cases have no entry values at all, so no personal IRR or MOIC exists for Reynolds in any case. It cannot say the injection caused the returns: the counterfactual asset path is unidentified for each case, and for Mint the brand was already growing at 50% annual subscriber growth before entry. It cannot say anything about scalability: with one computable case, one celebrity principal, and no benchmark, the question whether the twentieth injection buyer gets the same pricing and audience response is untouched by this data.

5.3 Picking versus making

The design cannot separate selection skill from treatment effect, and the cases make the con-found concrete. Mint was selected already growing; the injection may have accelerated a trajectory that existed before entry. Wrexham was selected at the bottom of the English pyramid with a reportable GBP 1.478 million turnover base, where the percentage growth arithmetic is flattered by a small denominator; the selection of an asset with that much headroom is itself a skill, or luck, that the return figure does not decompose. The LeBron James / Liverpool contrast case, excluded under (I3), sharpens the warning: a 15–19x paper return over fifteen years with zero operational injection shows that league-wide multiple expansion alone can produce the kind of paper gain that naive attribution would credit to a celebrity. Any future test of the thesis needs a selection model, or at minimum a matched entry-multiple control, before the injection effect can be isolated.

5.4 The multiple-expansion mechanism

The one mechanism the data illuminate is multiple expansion on narrative. Across the sports cases, the pattern is consistent: entry at 1.5–3.7x revenue (Burnley about 1.5x, the Wrexham Allyn mark 3.7x) against current marks at 7–13x revenue on thin liquidity (Inter Miami about 7.3x on estimates, the unexplored Wrexham ask about 13x). None of the clubs is profitable, so the expansion is on revenue multiples, not earnings, and it prices a story about future monetization of the audience rather than current cash flow. This is the same channel that dominates buyout returns at the industry level (59% of 2010–2022 returns from multiple expansion and cheap debt; StepStone's GP-attributable multiple expansion negative in the 2025 update). For Wrexham the decomposition quantifies the split: 29% of the log move is multiple expansion, 71% is revenue growth. The unresolved question is how much of the multiple leg is a durable repricing of the asset's earnings power and how much is a mark on a minority transaction that

no buyer has yet validated at scale. The Apollo investment of December 2025, at undisclosed terms, is the next datapoint that could bear on it; it is not in this dataset.

6 Conclusion

Three outcomes were specified before analysis: (i) the full thesis is supported (injection-led turnarounds are a scalable institutional investment thesis); (ii) only a narrower variant is supported; (iii) the thesis is rejected.

The evidence supports the narrower variant (ii), provisionally: one documented case exists in which an audience injection coincided with outsized paper value creation, driven mostly by revenue growth (71% of the log move), plus two large filed asset-level exits with no computable investor return. Every qualifier in that sentence is load-bearing: single, paper, mostly revenue, filed (not realized deal value), no investor-level return.

The full scalable institutional thesis (i) is not supported. It would require multiple computable investor-level returns, realized exits, a matched stratum benchmark showing median excess returns, and a median that holds up under the survivorship sensitivity. None exists: the treatment sample is $n = 1$ computable and unrealized, the benchmark comparison is blocked by missing stratum and sector data, and scalability equilibrium is untestable in this sample.

Rejection (iii) is not warranted either. The data are insufficient to reject: absence of evidence of returns is not evidence of absence, and Wrexham stands as an existence proof that an audience injection can coincide with a 54.4x paper entry-to-mark move alongside three consecutive promotions and a 22-fold turnover increase.

What would move the verdict toward (i): disclosed entry values or stake sizes for the brand cases; realized (not marked) exits; two or more computable MOICs so the pre-specified sign test can run; a football-club sector counterfactual (Deloitte/UEFA revenue-growth and multiple series); a StepStone vintage/size stratum MOIC distribution for percentile placement; and entry-multiple-matched controls to separate picking from making. What would move the verdict toward (iii): a realized Wrexham exit well below the USD 136 million mark; documentation that the follow-on funding brings true investor equity MOIC near or below the PE control median of 3.19x; or a screened (not hand-picked) set of injection attempts showing median returns at or below capital-only controls after survivorship adjustment. Until such evidence exists, the honest position is the narrow one, held provisionally and stated with every caveat attached.

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A Case tables

A.1 Wrexham AFC: reported financials

All figures are press reports of Wrexham AFC Limited accounts filed at Companies House (year ends 30 June). The filings were not inspected directly.

Table 3: Wrexham AFC reported financials, FY2020–FY2025

FY	Turnover (GBP m)	Pre-tax result	Matchday	Commercial	Retail
2020 (pre-takeover)	1.478	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a
2022	5.97	loss 2.9	2.65	1.05	1.30
2023	10.48	loss 5.1	3.12	1.88	3.43
2024	26.7	loss 2.7	5.02	13.2	4.46
2025	33.35	loss 14.85	5.9	17.3	5.0

Supporting facts (REPORTED throughout): shareholder loans rose from GBP 3.7 million (FY2022) to GBP 9.0 million (FY2023); GBP 15 million of loans and interest were repaid in full by March 2025 after the Allyn investment; a GBP 27.5 million facility was repaid on 8 December 2025 when Apollo invested. The wage bill reached GBP 19.9 million in FY2025. FY2025 one-offs include a GBP 3.76 million write-off (Argentex insolvency), GBP 2.62 million paid to Maximum Effort and GBP 1.38 million to More Better for commercial work, and a GBP 2.59 million marketing contribution toward “Welcome to Wrexham.” 57.7% of FY2025 turnover came from outside the UK. Three consecutive promotions: National League champions 2022–23, League Two runners-up 2023–24, League One runners-up 2024–25; Championship football in 2025–26, the club’s first second-tier season since the early 1980s.

A.2 Brand treatment cases: entry and exit legs

The entry leg is empty in both cases; that emptiness is the binding constraint on the paper.

A.3 Control table

The value basis is named per row; MIXED rows do not enter ratio calculations.

* Near-total, not clean total, losses (see Section 4.3).

A.4 Failure-mode references (excluded cases)

Salford City: six consecutive seasons in League Two (2019–2025) under celebrity ownership and spending; celebrity plus capital stalled. Crawley Town (WAGMI United): crypto-led injection, five managers in the first year, 22nd in League Two in 2022–23, then a distressed pass-on to KB Sports and Leisure in 2025; no value creation demonstrated. Adidas-Yeezy: partnership terminated October 2022 over conduct; Adidas guided to about EUR 1.2 billion in lost 2023 revenue and ended 2023 with a EUR 58 million net loss; the brand had no standalone enterprise value without Adidas. Diageo/Combs: partnership dissolved January 2024 with no disclosed financial terms. Celebrity SPACs (Beachbody, The Parent Company): 80–86% drawdowns with no operating turnaround attempted.

Table 4: Brand treatment cases: what is filed, what is reported, what is unknown

	Aviation Gin / Davos Brands	Mint Mobile / Ka’ena
Entry	Reynolds bought a “significant” stake, Feb 2018, as owner/creative director. Price and exact stake undisclosed.	Reynolds acquired ownership stake, late 2019, as owner/creative face. Price and exact stake undisclosed (about 25% reported, unconfirmed).
Exit (FILED)	Diageo 20-F: up to USD 612m (USD 337m cash + up to USD 275m earnout over 10 years). Closed 30 Sep 2020.	T-Mobile 10-K FY2023: up to USD 1.35B (39% cash / 61% stock). Closed 1 May 2024.
Realized portion	Earnout up to 44.9% of filed max; achievement undisclosed.	Net upfront USD 939m; earnout up to USD 420m (31.1% of max), payable 1 Aug 2026, achievement unknown.
Partial exit	Reynolds retained ongoing ownership. Consideration covers Davos Brands LLC too (Astral, Sombra, TYKU).	Reynolds stayed on in creative role.
Scale at exit	~53,000 US cases in 2019 (REPORTED, Impact Databank). Revenue never disclosed.	~3m subscribers (REPORTED Wells Fargo estimate); 50%/yr subscriber and 70%+/yr revenue growth disclosed by T-Mobile.

B Methodology details

Currency. All monetary cells are USD millions. GBP converted at approximate monthly-average spot rates: 1.39 USD/GBP (February 2021), 1.31 USD/GBP (October 2024). Original GBP values retained in dataset notes cells.

Holding periods. Wrexham: February 2021 to October 2024, 3.67 years. Aviation: February 2018 to September 2020, 2.67 years. Mint: late 2019 to 1 May 2024, 4.42 years.

Stratum matching bands (specified, not executed). Sector (Damodaran sector, or Deloitte/UEFA segment for clubs); entry year ± 2 years or vintage band; deal-size bucket (terciles of log enterprise value within the sample); asset type (football club, consumer brand, operating company); geography (UK/EU/US) where sector norms differ. If a stratum contains fewer than about 30 StepStone buyouts, the protocol falls back to the broader sector distribution and flags the case as weakly matched; headline results are reported with and without weakly matched cases. Execution was blocked because the dataset contains no stratum-level MOIC distribution.

Excess decomposition (specified, not executed). For case i with stratum benchmark median MOIC M_s , excess log return $e_i = \ln \text{MOIC}_i - \ln M_s$. The market-only counterfactual is $\text{EV}_{\text{cf}} = \text{Rev}_{\text{entry}} \times (1 + g_{\text{sector}}) \times m_{\text{entry}} \times k_{\text{sector,exit}}$, giving (a) market beta $\ln(\text{EV}_{\text{cf}}/\text{EV}_{\text{entry}})$; (b) replicable operating alpha, the excess revenue growth and excess margin expansion versus sector; and (c) the owner-specific residual $e_i - (a) - (b)$, labeled everywhere as unexplained excess, an upper bound on the injection effect only under correct measurement of (a) and (b). Execution was blocked by missing g_{sector} , margin, and sector-multiple inputs.

Small- n rules applied. The sample reports medians, ranges, and full case tables. No t -statistics, no normal-based intervals, no regressions, no population claims. The pre-specified primary test (sign test and Wilcoxon signed-rank on median excess MOIC) was not run: $n = 1$ computable and unrealized.

Table 5: Control cases: non-celebrity PE turnarounds, 3G playbook cases, total losses

ID	Company	Sponsor(s)	Entry → exit (reported basis)	Basis
CTL-01	Hilton	Blackstone	~USD 6.5B equity → ~USD 14B reported profit; 3.19x reconstructed equity (11y)	Equity (recon.)
CTL-02	HCA	Bain, KKR, Merrill Lynch	USD 956M → USD 3.14B proceeds (Bain fund); 3.28x partial (7y)	Equity (partial)
CTL-03	Dollar General	KKR	~USD 2.8B equity → ~150% paper gain at IPO; 2.50x (2.3y)	Equity
CTL-04	Burger King	TPG, Bain, GS	USD 1.5B EV → USD 4.0B EV (8y); 2.67x EV	EV
CTL-05	Hertz	CD&R, Carlyle, Merrill Lynch	Indeterminate (exit cell is 2013 sale only)	n/a
CTL-06	Nielsen	Blackstone et al.	0.72x entry EV vs exit market cap	MIXED
CTL-07	Alltel	TPG, GS	USD 27.5B EV → USD 28.1B EV (1.2y); 1.02x EV	EV
CTL-08	AB InBev	3G Capital	Stock ~3.0x 2009–2015; no exit	Price
CTL-09	Kraft Heinz	3G / Berkshire	10y price return –73.5%; 0.265x	Price
CTL-10	Energy Future Hldgs	KKR, TPG, GS	Chapter 11 (2014); sponsor equity ~USD 8B wiped out	0.0x
CTL-11	Toys “R” Us	Bain, KKR, Vornado	Bankruptcy 2017, liquidation 2018; ~USD 1.3B equity wiped out	0.0x
CTL-12	Caesars	Apollo, TPG	Chapter 11 (2015); near-total loss (residual reorganized equity)	0.0x*
CTL-13	iHeartMedia	Bain, THL	Chapter 11 (2018); lenders took 94% of reorganized stock	0.0x
CTL-14	Neiman Marcus	Ares, CPP	Chapter 11 (2020); CPP reported no net proceeds	0.0x*

C Limitations

1. *Entry-side opacity.* No celebrity entry price or exact stake is disclosed in any treatment case. No personal IRR or MOIC is computable for any case. This is the single largest data gap and it is binding: the entire return side of the brand leg is missing.
2. *Sample size.* One computable treatment return ($n = 1$), unrealized. No inferential test on excess returns is licensed. The sample is a case series, not a random draw, and estimates no population parameter.
3. *Unrealized marks.* All treatment “returns” are paper marks; there has been no realized exit in the treatment set. The Wrexham 54.40x is an interim mark on a minority transaction, treated as an upper bound because it ignores more than GBP 25 million of owner-funded cumulative losses. Interim marks are appraisal-based and stale; they understate volatility and typically drawdowns.
4. *No benchmark comparison computable.* The StepStone stratum percentile and the Damodaran sector counterfactual could not be computed from the dataset; neither was proxied, so the paper makes no excess-return claim.
5. *Survivorship.* The observed sample overrepresents successes by construction; no registry of failed celebrity brands exists. The sensitivity table is a bound, not a correction; the true unobserved failure rate is unknown and the imputed total-loss severity is deliberately conservative.
6. *Picking versus making unidentified.* The design cannot separate selection skill from treatment effect; the counterfactual asset path is unidentified for each case ($n = 1$ per case). All three treatment cases trace to one celebrity principal, so the evidence cannot distinguish a person-specific playbook from an institutional one.

7. *Kraft Heinz figures.* The FY2018 revenue (USD 26.3 billion), net loss (USD 10.2 billion), and 2024 revenue (USD 25.8 billion) came via secondary compilation: SEC EDGAR returned HTTP 403 to automated retrieval during evidence collection, so the 10-K was not inspected directly. They are labeled “audited/ filed (via secondary compilation)” and must be confirmed from the 10-K before publication.
8. *Damodaran figures.* Sector multiples (food processing 14.0x, household products 16.0x, retail grocery and food 10.0x, hotel/gaming 11.0x, healthcare services 13.0x, media 11.0x) came via secondary transcription of the January 2026 `valuation.xls` update and must be verified against the source file before model use.
9. *Control set construction.* The seven PE turnarounds are hand-picked mega-deals (2002–2007 vintages), not a screened sample; rows mix enterprise value with sponsor equity and the value-basis column records the basis per row. No statistical claim about control distributions is licensed.
10. *Single-source dependency.* All three treatment cases trace to Ryan Reynolds. Salford and Crawley show celebrity injections failing or stalling, but they were excluded under (I4), so they cannot enter the return sample and the failure side of the distribution is under-observed by design.